

PA. STEEL TOWN IS BREATHING NEW LIFE

Important things haven't changed

You can go home again.

At least, you can if you can withstand the shock of seeing your grandmother's white house painted pink and the public swimming pool that your grandfather campaigned for filled in and covered with grass.

On my trip across America, my husband and I detoured to Monaca, Pa., a town of about 6,000 on the Ohio River where my grandparents and great-grandparents lived. It was going to be a purely personal stop. I didn't intend to write a word about Monaca (pronounced muh-nack-uh).

But what I found in this plain-faced industrial town, one of a string of river cities that once formed the backbone of the nation's steel industry, said more about the resiliency of this country than it did about me or any of the other people who once lived in that old white house.

When I was a child visiting my grandparents in the 1940s, Monaca was a bustling town filled with people of German, Irish, Polish and Italian ancestry. Each morning, the men trudged off together to the steel mills or the other manufacturing plants that belched black smoke into the sky over the river. Everyone had the same goal: to earn enough money to give their families a better life.

In those days, the air was so dirty that my grandmother had to clean the grime off her flowered wallpaper every year. My grandfather, who worked in the mills from the age of 13 until he retired as a foreman at age 73, came home covered with so much grease that he undressed in the basement. I still remember the metallic smell of his clothes. It was a good smell, because it reminded me of him.

In the 1960s, the U.S. steel industry began collapsing because of low-priced foreign steel, and Monaca and all the other little mill towns entered a period of upheaval. Thousands of workers lost their jobs, and plants stood like empty gray hulks along the river. Monaca's downtown, which had never been especially beautiful, seemed forlorn, with vacant

REAL ESTATE PRICES: BY THE NUMBERS

\$79,000: Current price of a three-bedroom house built in 1946 in Monaca, Pa.

\$699,900: Current price of a three-bedroom house built in 1946 in North Park.

SOURCES: SignOnSanDiego.com, Pittsburghmoves.com

It had been almost 20 years since I'd last passed through Monaca, so when we pulled into town last week, I didn't know what to expect. My relatives had either died or moved away. And after all the town had been through, I feared it would be a depressing shell of the place I remembered.

What I quickly realized, however, is that while people live and die, and economies thrive and wither, the essence of a community sometimes survives.

We parked our car across from my grandparents' house and headed "down street" as my grandfather used to call the five-or six-block walk to Pennsylvania Avenue, the heart of town. The houses we passed had been touched up here and there. The merry-go-round at the playground had been replaced by a plastic climbing apparatus. But people still nodded from their front porches, just as they had when my grandfather and I walked those blocks hand-in-hand. And even though I didn't know them, and they certainly didn't know me, I still felt like I had come home.

Even the ethnic mix was the same. According to the most recent census, Monaca is 97 percent white, with people continuing to describe themselves as German, Irish, Polish and Italian.

We found the house where my grandparents' young neighbors lived, and they were still there, in their 70s now.

Cookie Polce had worked in the mills most of his life. In the old days, he would stop by my grandmother's back porch after work and they'd laugh together over the latest mill jokes.

His wife, Theo, had raised their four children and worked in a real estate office. When my grandparents grew old, Theo helped with the housecleaning.

Theo was full of news about the town. A new bakery had opened, and a pet store and a pharmacy. A new steel-fabricating plant was hiring. And a new Italian restaurant was coming.

Theo was doing her part to help push the town into the future.

A few years ago, she noticed that the flower beds on Pennsylvania Avenue were filled with trash and cigarette butts. So she started weeding and sweeping and picking up the junk. Eventually three women and a man joined her, all of them in their 70s. They call

COMMENTS

thank you, you made me cry for the past and gave me hope for the future.

★ Posted by: teresa kruchas | [June 17, 2007 09:51 AM](#)

I never want 20 years to go by without visiting my hometown.

★ Posted by: KB | [June 17, 2007 02:12 PM](#)

Dear Ms. White,

I loved your article about Monaca, PA. I too grow up in a small rural community like yours, Los Banos, California; pronounced (Loos Ban-yos). I remember riding my bike from one side of town to the other. Cruising Main Street on a Saturday nights, the wide-open space, and the annual May-day Fair. That was a high point for me, everyone you knew, and past and present would all come to the fair. Of course with a population of 10,000, 90% white, 5% Hispanic, and 5% other (from 1970-1980); not much changed.

After I joined the Marine Corps, I noticed a change in my beautiful small town; foreigners. By the hundreds they began to pour in, mostly illegal Mexicans who were taking advantage of the 1986 amnesty.

Today, I rarely visit my hometown; population of 40,000, 65% Hispanic, 30% White, and 5% other. My dad still lives in the same home that I grew up in, but the neighborhood has become dilapidated. To drive down Main Street is depressing. The corner drug store where I would buy my ice cream with mom, has been replaced with a Mexican restaurant. Flimsy businesses that cater to Spanish speaking immigrants have popped up. Crime had increased, and murders, which were never heard of during my youth have significantly increased; much has changed.

Unlike your town of Monaca that has seen many social and economic changes, mine has fallen into what is my opinion, despair. I don't plan to visit Los Banos anytime soon, and my dad; well I'll call more frequently.

Sincerely

Alex R. Garcia

★ Posted by: Alex R. Garcia | [June 17, 2007 02:38 PM](#)

where they lived in town.

My favorite memory is sitting on my grandparents porch swing on a summer night listening to the Pirates game filter out through the wooden screen door.

★ Posted by: C. Weigle | [June 17, 2007 03:09 PM](#)

Susan,

Thanks for the article about Monaca. I grew up in the 70's living in Ambridge (noted for its many churches and beer gardens), a few miles down the road from Monaca. In May, we recently visited our relatives that still living in Beaver County. The trip was very enjoyable and gave us time to have flashbacks of the way it was. One thing that hasn't change is that its still one of the most beautiful areas of our great country. I know the area is still reinventing itself and it will, history shows it. Once again it will become a booming area. After leaving Ambridge in 1982 and spending over 22 year in the Marine Corps my family and I call Oceanside our home. But I can't help myself of never say never of moving back to that area. It was and still a great place to raise a family. Sidenote: Monaca had a great baseball team, I was lucky enough to have beat them only one time when I played for Quigley High and Ambridge American Legion teams. Hope younz have a safe trip.

★ Posted by: P. Tisak | [June 17, 2007 11:06 PM](#)

Nice fluff piece but far from the reality of the people who were forced to adjust from a good paying middle class job to the ensuing struggles so many families endured after the closing of the mill. Furthermore, the US domestic steel industry was booming in the 60's. It was not until the late 70's when Japanese steel was being dumped on our shores were our steel jobs affected. So I must question the validity of the softball observation done by the reporter.

★ Posted by: darrel barrel | [June 18, 2007 08:07 AM](#)

I, too, grew up in Monaca, Pa. And lived there until three years ago, when my husband and I moved to Port Charlotte, Fl. Susan, what was your maiden name? Did you graduate from Monaca? What year? My maiden name is Reese, and I graduated from Monaca in 1970. I have two older sisters, one who graduated in 1965, and one in 1968. I also have a younger brother, who graduated in 1983. My husband's cousin is also orginally from Monaca, and she sent me your article from San Diego. Monaca is the kind of town that can leave you with so many heartwarming memories, and makes me glad to have been able to

kids lol,,,I remember so many of my childhood classmates at Washington elementary school,,,awwwwww to have stayed in monaca and never have left,,,oh how i wish that's what we had done,,,but my dad also had to leave to find work,,,and sadly we never moved back,,,thank you again for the memories

★ Posted by: doreen (mayhew) bowers | [June 18, 2007 01:01 PM](#)

Great article! What a surprise to find my hometown mentioned in the U-T. I was born in Rochester, PA and raised in Aliquippa and Monaca, PA. As a 1958 graduate of Monaca High School I remember the soot on the front porch on the mornings slowly swirling around in response to the gentle breezes. The white paint on the houses turned black in a few years due to the sulfur in the air. But the mills, especially J & L Steel in Aliquippa, that put out these dirt and fumes were the mills in which my grandfathers, my father, my uncles and aunts and I worked in to raise families and help fuel the robust economy of those times. My Dad used to tell me about working at the Phoenix Glass Co. in Monaca as a youngster, then at J & L Steel, then at the Curtis-Wright plant in Beaver during WWII, then back to J & L for the rest of career. He and I sometimes worked the same shift at J & L. I have MANY fond memories of growing up in Monaca, some of which are growing dim since I moved away from that area 27 years ago. But I recall Bender's Pharmacy, Callagan's Pharmacy, Lou & Werner's Barber Shop, Monaca Methodist Church, the Masonic Lodge, Smitty's Atlantic Gas Station (where I worked through high school), Dr. Milliron (a very good GP), Skeeter Hill, Presto's Pizza, the five and dime store, Miller's Market, Graeser's Auto Body Shop and more. I've been in San Diego for 23 years but visit Monaca at least every 5 years for my High School reunion. I'm looking forward to visiting there again next year to visit my remaing family in the area, get caught up with my classmates and to see the renewal you described. Thanks for bringing back the memories.

★ Posted by: Robert C. Haney | [June 18, 2007 01:28 PM](#)

I grew up in Monaca in the 60's and graduated HS there in 1972. I stayed away for many years and finally went to a HS reunion in 2002. Thanks for the grea article!

★ Posted by: JD ZIEGLER | [June 18, 2007 03:37 PM](#)

Dear Susan, I posted an e-mail today, but never saw it. My grandmother live by Cookie and she knew them well. In fact, that house used to be the Hemer's (spelling). Seeing all the people from Monaca and the area who now live here in SD, I wish we could all get in touch with each other. That would be so great. I went to 3rd Ward School (my Grandma lived across the street next to Matteo's). I think we all wish we could get in touch with each other. I moved to SD in 1986. Thank you for the great article. I am also a friend of

forwarded the link to your article to my cousin in San Diego to share with her dad who grew up here. You mentioned the swimming pool... my kids are some of the last that were able to swim in that pool. It was a shame to see it go. Happy travels to you!!

★ Posted by: Rosanne | [June 19, 2007 09:00 AM](#)

Your article was forwarded to me by a cousin. I was glad to read about the town in which I have worked for the last 31 years. I know the Polce family and was glad to see a familiar name in your article.

Monaca is a nice little town. The people are friendly. These opinions were formed as far back as when I was a kid visiting many relatives, playing at the playgrounds and swimming at the pool.

Anyone who drives through the main street can see how the people of Monaca are trying to provide a thriving town for all.

Come back and visit soon!

★ Posted by: Lou Ann | [June 20, 2007 07:34 PM](#)

We must all do our part, no matter where we live.

Many towns would be more beautiful if individuals took care of their property as well as volunteer to help others.

On the outskirts of "downtown" Monaca, Rome Monument has built two facilities, plus an industrial park has been modernized at a former steel mill. At the other end of town, the shining "new" Monaca Library was moved from the old house it occupied for decades.

An eye doctor has also built a brand new office building in the heart of downtown.

This revitalization is a start, and hopefully it will continue.

★ Posted by: Irene | [June 22, 2007 04:46 AM](#)

Hi Susan; Thank you for such a warm, uplifting story about "our town". I met you the evening you stopped at our Monaca Hall of Fame and have relayed your article to many, many people here and elsewhere. I share your perception of this town and have lived here most of my life. I truly believe our small towns have built this nation. We just need interested, willing, and devoted people to maintain them. Thank you and perhaps we shall meet again. Marlene

★ Posted by: Marlene | [June 23, 2007 08:33 AM](#)

Welcome back!

We sure enjoyed reading about your trip. You both write beautifully...could a book be far behind?

★ Posted by: Jere & Cyndi | [June 24, 2007 01:21 PM](#)

I have never visited Monaca. But I do know a few people who live there , and the L.O.M.L. was born and raised there. So i have heard stories and looked at photos,that were taken there at the Stephan Phillips Housing Development.

But until i read the descriptions that have been posted . I had know Idiea of how , it must have been there yrs. ago.

And yes i know the smell of oil and grease that work men had on their clothes. Because i have known that odor from the men here or at one time , but all gone now due to the closing of the steel mills here . ohh and the red lead paint that got on everthing . so after reading about Monaca, it brought back the memory, of those by gone days. It broght tears to my eyes and a big lump in my throat.

And it also made me understand how most all steel towns that once florished are just memories.

It hurts to think of all the steel mills that closed and all the families, that felt and saw their dreams go poof.

Yes its sad that they now buy steel made in other countries.

Cheeper Yes But as good
no.

AND THAT GIVES ME A BITTER TASTE IN MY MOUTH.

But im glad Monaca still stcks together and tryies to keep the town clean and beautiful.

Also I loved reading about it. I hope Monaca never gives up.

Prof. John P. Slivak

NiceTown Pa. 19140 Phila. Co.

Once the Home of The MIDVALE STEEL Co.

★ Posted by: [John P. Slivak Sci.Dr.Astm.Ltd.](#) | [June 24, 2007 11:10 PM](#)

So it is a small world! Living in Sacramento now, grew up in Monaca (class of 72). This article was forwarded to me by a hs classmate still living in the area. I have been spending quite a bit of time back there taking care of my mother, and enjoy the solid, easy pace of life and the quality and caring people as portrayed in your article. After being away 30 years, the last 2 1/2 years visits back have made me realize what a special place it was -- and is!

★ Posted by: Michaeline (Pinksaw) Veden | [June 25, 2007 04:21 PM](#)

My husband was reading your article because he went to Penn State for his Masters and eventually worked at US Steel as an Engineer. He showed the article to me because the name "Cookie Polce" was in the article. My maiden name is Polce and I am originally from Providence, Rhode Island. I came to San Diego in 1994 for employment, later married my husband who is originally from Massachusetts, small world. I am very interested in the "Cookie Polce" family since Polce is a very unusual name. We have relatives in Rome, New York also, but that was only one of my grandfather's brothers, and unfortunately I don't know all my grandfather's siblings. They are the only two that I know of that came from Italy together. I would appreciate any information you may remember about the Polce family in Monaca. Thank You

★ Posted by: Jo Ann (Polce) Della Polce | [June 27, 2007 03:09 PM](#)

My Dad (Butch Budacki) sent me the article from Florida where he & my mother (Theresa Kraft Budacki) now reside, 5 years removed from being forced into early retirement from ARCO Chemical. My mother was born & raised in Monaca (class of '65 I think). I have moved from Rochester (class of '92) to New Brighton & I teach Biology at Rochester. I know that the County has lost a bit of its luster, but the people are still as vibrant & inspiring as ever... Thanks

★ Posted by: Bob Budacki | [July 5, 2007 11:48 AM](#)

Susan,

That was a very nice article written about a town that I will always love. I grew up in Monaca during the 70's and early 80's. I lived on Walnut St. on the hill and can still remember riding my bike down 14 St, I also remember having to ride it back up it! I remember big gangs of us kids walking down the hill to football games and the smell in the air. I remember when the tornado hit in 1970 and though very young, I remember where I was at when it hit. But the thing I remember the most, still holds true today, the people. The people there are some of the most friendly that I've ever met, always welcoming you whether or not they know you. I hope Monaca continues to change, always evolving, always redefining itself but I hope the people there never lose their endearing qualities.

Thanks again

★ Posted by: Jeff Starcher | [July 18, 2007 04:37 AM](#)

(a German warbride) and myself (at age 3) to the valley. He had hopes of getting out of the coal mines of WVA and into the steel mills (which were begging for workers at the time). Unfortunately, my father only graduated from the 5th grade and the steel mills required a high school diploma. He found work at a very small company back then - Armstrong Cork. He retired from Armstrong in the 80's. I attended St. Mary's Grade School in Beaver Falls (now Divine Providence). I graduated from Mt. Gallitzin High School; but had to attend the newly built (or should I say half-built) Quigley High School in Baden my senior year 1967-1968. I left the valley in 1979 for Houston, Texas which is where I am now. My parents waited until they were in their late 70's to sell everything and "retire" to Florida (where my brother lives). Unlike many other retirees, they did not like Florida, and returned to PA when they were in their early 80's. They are now in Marienville, but visit the valley often. My plans are to return to the valley when I retire. There's no place like home, and I miss it more and more each year. I'm so pleased each time I get a chance to visit there, that everyone still has "SPIRIT" and pride in the community. There's a closeness there that I have not found elsewhere. I have wonderful childhood memories from there and I want to have the last part of my life there too. There's hard times almost everywhere. The difference I see with Beaver Valley is that people seem to pull together and help each other. Not so in other places. Thanks to everyone who wrote in for the great memories and reminders of what I have to look forward to in my golden years.

Marianne (Ramsey) Johnston
Houston, Texas

★ Posted by: Marianne (Ramsey) Johnston | [December 30, 2007 04:31 PM](#)

My grandmother Elizabeth (Betty) Pigza lived in Beaver County in 1930-they lived at 1215 Pennsylvania Ave i'm wondering if anyone out there knew them-she had a baby May 1930 (my dad) at the age of 17, her parents names were Michael & Anna Pigza-he was Slovak and worked as a grinder-you have a great website and i'm always interested in knowing things about Monaca and Pittsburgh-thank you.

★ Posted by: Liz Moros | [January 28, 2008 07:37 AM](#)

Susan, I was pleased to read your article on Monaca after it was forwarded to me by my daughter, Susan Brubaker Knapp, who once worked with you in Lexington. Having grown up in New Brighton in the 40's and 50bs, just a few miles from Monaca, I was treated to a bit of nostalgia about Beaver Valley. I visit there every now and then, and it is just as you describe. Thanks.

★ Posted by: Ellie | [February 12, 2008 03:12 PM](#)

★ Posted by: Sue Griffin Hall | [February 18, 2008 01:36 PM](#)

That's my family!!! Theo and Cookie are my grandparents. To see that is just astonishing, and i was just as surprised as anyone else who read this.

★ Posted by: Jerrod | [April 8, 2008 10:26 PM](#)

I grew up in Monaca, as well! My Dad was the President of the Union for the Pittsburgh Tube Co., Granville Andrew Cole. I, too, remember the path that led from Stephen Phillips to Toni Peroni's!

Guess what! Our teachers didn't care which child belonged to what parent; we all received an education that was worth a million! Thank You, Mrs. Hurts, Mrs. Massie, Mrs. Hezelp, Mrs. Youtes, Mr. Laughlin, Mr. Hoffman!

I remember the J&L traffic through Monaca that took us forever to cross "the toll bridge" into Freedom! Our end destination was usually the Northern Lights Shopping Center!

I remember the Monaca Swimming Pool and Coach Nichols!

I remember walking back and forth to the 4th Ward Elementary School, rain, shine, or snow! I remember a 45 minute lunch break in which we walked back and forth; leaving only 10 minutes to eat lunch!

God, I miss those days!

★ Posted by: Sharla Cole | [April 27, 2008 01:33 PM](#)

I grew up in Center- swimming at Monaca pool! I belonged to St. John's church in Monaca. I am shocked to read this article, and saddened to see how many have moved away. We had it so good back then and we didn't even know it. Great story, thanks!

★ Posted by: Carol Schmidt | [May 18, 2008 09:58 AM](#)
